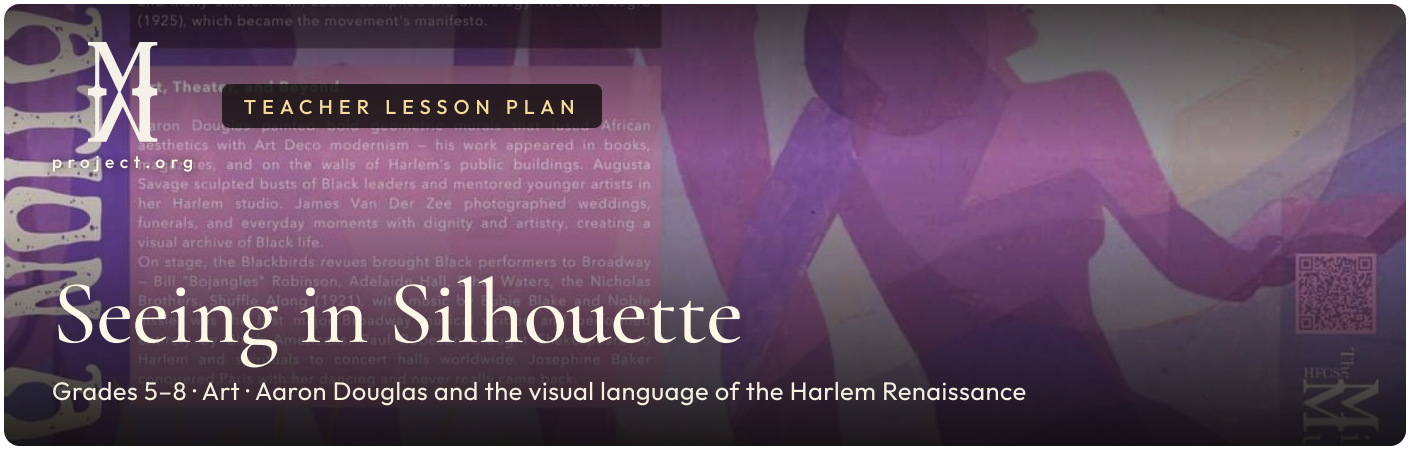


TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Seeing in Silhouette

Grades 5–8 · Art · Aaron Douglas and the visual language of the Harlem Renaissance

THE 39 MINUTES

5 min	12 min	22 min
HOOK	DIRECT INSTRUCTION	ACTIVITY

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will analyze Aaron Douglas's distinctive visual style — flat geometric silhouettes, layered concentric circles, African design influences, and deliberate use of color to evoke emotion and narrative. They will understand how formal art choices carry meaning and argument, and respond through their own silhouette composition or analytical writing.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **National Arts VA:Re7.1** — Hypothesize ways in which art influences perception and understanding of human experiences
- **National Arts VA:Re8.1** — Interpret art by analyzing and using contextual information to develop an interpretation
- **National Arts VA:Cr2.1** — Demonstrate awareness of ethical implications of creating art and making design decisions
- **CCSS.ELA SL.5–8.4** — Present claims and findings using appropriate description, facts, and relevant details

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Printed or projected Aaron Douglas images — the handouts name each work; ideal to also display large-format
- For studio activity: black card or paper, scissors, colored backgrounds (construction paper or watercolor wash on white card); alternatively, pencil and colored pencils for composition sketches
- Differentiated handouts — one per student

Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Aspects of Negro Life: The Negro in an African Setting (1934) · Aspects of Negro Life: From Slavery Through Reconstruction (1934) · Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934) · The Creation (1935) · Harriet Tubman (1931)

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

What do you see?

Project *Song of the Towers* (1934) without any introduction. Ask students to write three observations in 60 seconds — not interpretations, just observations.

"Don't tell me what it means yet. Tell me what you see. Be specific — shapes, colors, positions of figures, what's in the background, what's in the foreground."

Take 5–6 responses. Then: *"This painting was made in 1934 by Aaron Douglas. He was the leading visual artist of the Harlem Renaissance. Today we're going to figure out how he made it work — and why."*

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 12 MINUTES

Douglas's visual language

Walk through Douglas's five signature techniques:

- **Flat silhouettes:** figures rendered without facial features — universal, archetypal, collective rather than individual
- **Concentric circles:** light radiating outward from a center — spiritual energy, sound waves, divine presence
- **African geometric pattern:** influenced by Egyptian hieroglyphics and West African textile design — a deliberate reclamation of African visual heritage
- **Limited, symbolic color palette:** each painting uses 3–5 colors with specific emotional associations
- **Layered transparency:** figures overlap in semi-transparent layers — collective history, multiple times existing simultaneously

> *"Douglas was trained in European art — he knew exactly what 'mainstream' painting looked like. He chose not to paint that way. Every choice he made was deliberate: the silhouettes say 'this is everyone, not one person.' The concentric circles say 'there is spiritual power here.' The African patterns say 'we come from somewhere ancient and magnificent.' His paintings were arguments made in color and shape."*

ACTIVITY · 22 MINUTES

Students choose a handout.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Complete a structured visual analysis of *Song of the Towers* using five guided questions. Then create a simple silhouette figure in the style of Douglas — black on colored background, one symbol added.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Analyze two Douglas works — compare how he uses the same techniques in different emotional contexts. Create a silhouette composition with at least three figures and a symbolic background. Write a 3-sentence artist statement.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Full formal analysis of three works across all five technique dimensions. Write a 2-paragraph critical interpretation arguing what Douglas's visual choices communicate about Black identity and history. Optional studio: respond in your own silhouette composition with written rationale.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: online at the address below.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

DOUGLAS'S BIOGRAPHY

Key facts

Born	1899, Topeka, Kansas
Died	1979, Nashville, Tennessee
Education	University of Nebraska (BA, 1922); studied with Winold Reiss in New York; later studied in Paris
Harlem arrival	1925 — immediately became the leading visual artist of the Renaissance
Major works	*Aspects of Negro Life* (1934, four-panel mural, Schomburg Center); *Song of the Towers* (1934); Fisk University murals (1930)
Later career	Founded the Art Department at Fisk University, Nashville (1944–1966) — trained generations of Black artists

TEACHER REFERENCE

The five techniques

01
Flat Silhouettes

By removing facial features, Douglas creates figures that are universal and archetypal rather than individual. This connects to African sculptural traditions and Egyptian hieroglyphic art — and implicitly argues that Black figures deserve the same archetypal status as figures in European classical art.

02
Concentric Circles

The radiating circles that appear in almost every Douglas work suggest sound (jazz resonance), spiritual energy (divine light), and shared emotion. They give the paintings a sense of vibration and pulse — as if the image itself is making sound.

03
African Geometric Design

Douglas was deeply influenced by his study of West African art and Egyptian imagery. The geometric patterns in his backgrounds deliberately evoke pre-colonial African visual culture — arguing that Black Americans have a rich aesthetic heritage predating slavery.

04
Limited, Symbolic Color Palette

Each painting uses 3–5 colors with specific emotional associations.

05
Layered Transparency

The semi-transparent overlapping figures suggest that multiple historical moments coexist — past, present, and future simultaneously visible. This is Douglas's visual equivalent of what W.E.B. Du Bois called "double consciousness."

CROSS-CURRICULAR AND ASSESSMENT NOTES

- **ELA connection:** Douglas and Langston Hughes were close collaborators — Douglas illustrated Hughes's books. Have students compare a Hughes poem to a Douglas image on a similar theme
- **Social Studies:** the four-panel *Aspects of Negro Life* mural tells a complete historical narrative from African roots to the Great Migration — a visual equivalent of a history textbook
- **Catholic context:** the spiritual imagery in Douglas's concentric circles invites reflection on how art can express the sacred — connects to the Catholic tradition of sacred art using visual language to express transcendence
- **Assessment:** formal analysis writing; sketchbook studio response; artist statement; comparative analysis presentation